

TRIBUTE TEA

In ancient China, every emperor expected tea leaves from the first harvest of the most highly valued gardens to be given to him as a “tribute.” This practice benefited growers and increased sales of teas that had received the emperor’s endorsement.

The tradition of producing “tribute teas” has evolved into the current practice in China of celebrating 10 famous teas each year. The list rarely changes from year to year, featuring mostly green teas, a few oolongs, and a black tea.

THE MODERN AGE

After the communist revolution in 1949, China isolated itself from the outside world, closing its doors for business and tourism to foreigners. This inadvertently helped to preserve traditional tea recipes and production processes. However, when the Cultural Revolution of the 1960s and 1970s swept the country, cultural artifacts and historic sites were lost in the attempt to “purge” the country of non-communist influences. While it is hard to estimate how this affected tea culture in particular, the country’s recent interest in its rich past includes a resurgence in tea drinking.

ORNATE FANS

Women and men used beautifully decorated fans to cool themselves while enjoying tea.

CHINA’S TEA RENAISSANCE

Tea remains an important part of life in China. Taxi drivers have their ubiquitous jar of green tea in the cup holder of their cabs; there are schools that teach girls the fine art of presenting tea, so that they can take it up as a profession in China’s many tea houses. Chinese tea producers are developing new black teas (known in China as “red teas”) to appeal to the Western palate. In 2006, Jin Jun Mei, a new type of Lapsang Souchong from Wuyi, was introduced, and has since become quite sought after.

Tea tourism has also become popular, with enthusiasts visiting the tea cliffs of the Wuyi Mountains in Fujian province; the West Lake area of Hangzhou in Zhejiang province; or exploring the many tea-themed boutique hotels and restaurants of Lijiang in Yunnan province. Hong Kong draws many enthusiasts, too, as much for its famous milk tea (see the recipe on p176), as for Flagstaff House. Once the residence of the commander of the British forces, it now houses a teaware museum boasting the world’s oldest surviving teapot.

BUDDHIST MONKS WERE THE FIRST TO CULTIVATE TEA AND SPREAD THIS KNOWLEDGE

PU’ER TEA

Pu’er tea was pressed into cakes and wrapped in rice paper.

